HOORVIA - PAPER RETENTION GUIDELINES: PRINTABLE DOCUMENT STORAGE CHART

Quick Reference Cheat Sheet · US Letter Printable

Home, Family & Health · Sheet #1

Document	Keep For	Why This Long	When Done
Tax Returns (filed copy)	Forever	Your proof of filing; IRS can ask years later	Keep the filed copy permanently
Tax Supporting Documents	3 years from filing	General IRS audit window	Shred after 3 years
W-2s & 1099s	3 years	Match the return; IRS holds copies too	Shred with the return's records
Bad Debt & Worthless Securities	7 years	Extended IRS window for loss claims	Shred after 7 years
Employment Tax Records	At least 4 years	IRS rule after tax due or paid	Shred after 4 years
Pay Stubs	1 year	Until the W-2 is verified	Shred once W-2 matches
Bank Statements	1 year (3 if tax-related)	Reconciling and deduction proof	Shred; keep tax-related 3 years
Credit Card Statements	1 year (7 if tax-related)	Disputes and deductible purchases	Shred; keep tax-related 7 years
Mortgage & Loan Papers	Life of loan + 7 years	Proof of payoff and interest paid	Shred 7 years after payoff
Home Purchase & Improvement Records	Until sale + 3 years	Sets cost basis for capital gains	Shred 3 years after the sale
Medical Bills & Records	1 year paid; 7 if deducted	Insurance disputes and tax deductions	Shred after the window passes
Wills, Deeds & Birth Certificates	Forever	Irreplaceable legal originals	Store originals in a fireproof safe

PRO TIP: Three years is the baseline: Most tax records are safe to shred three years after filing - only bad-debt claims stretch the clock.